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English Language Arts
Mary, Star of the Sea School
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MSOS 2026-2027

English Language Arts — Grade 8 Syllabus

Empowered to succeed and guided by faith.

Course Description

Welcome to English Language Arts (ELA)! In this course, we'll strengthen our reading, writing, speaking, listening, and thinking skills. We'll read stories by diverse authors, create our own written pieces, and engage in thoughtful discussions. ELA is a space to explore ideas, ask questions, and grow as critical and creative thinkers.

Please bring: sticky notes, pencils, a composition notebook, your computer, and a dedicated ELA binder. We will use Google Classroom and other edtech programs to support learning.

I am excited to learn and grow with you in this special place where we are empowered to succeed and guided by faith. I hope we can establish and fortify a strong connection between home and school, making this a stellar year!

Teacher

Dr. Lacey Vasquez

Communication primarily through Google Classroom and email. Please reach out for any questions about your child's progress.

Materials

- Sticky notes
- Pencils
- Composition notebook
- Computer (school-issued)
- Dedicated ELA binder
- Google Classroom + edtech access

Grade 8 Goal — Promoting Ownership

Promotes ownership — students lead philosophical discussions and write across genres with confident reasoning, structure, and evidence. Theme: ideas and resilience.

Novels & Readings — Grade 8 (Ideas / Resilience)

- The Pearl by John Steinbeck
- A Long Walk to Water by Sue Park
- Hatchet by Gary Paulsen

Great literature gives the reader opportunities to experience the human condition across decades and centuries. Great literature also has a compelling theme that is expressed through literary devices. We may substitute novels with short stories that have equal literary merit.

Types of Writing

At all grade levels, we will have at least one multistage writing assignment in each quarter:

- Literary analysis
- Expository
- Persuasive
- Argumentative

Types of Speeches

- Storytelling
- Poetry Reading
- Dramatic Interpretation
- Research Presentations

Discussion Formats

- Socratic Seminar (summative assessment)
- p4C discussion circle
- Peer-to-peer
- Table talks

Grade Categories

Category	Weight	Notes
Homework	15%	At-home practice
Classwork	20%	Daily participation, engagement, seatwork
Quizzes	10%	Short formative assessments

Tests	15%	Summative assessments
Portfolio	15%	Student-maintained digital file
Projects & Essays	25%	Multistage

Grade Scale

A+ 100–97%	A 96–93%	A– 92–90%
B+ 89–87%	B 86–83%	B– 82–80%
C+ 79–77%	C 76–73%	C– 72–70%
D+ 69–67%	D 66–63%	D– 62–60%
F 59–0%		

No “Late Work” Policy

Students must turn in their assignments on the day it is due, at the time it is due. If you believe your circumstance or situation may be an exception, please contact me through email before the assignment is due.

All late assignments will be subject to a 10% penalty. All late work must be submitted by the next school (not class) day.

For work missed due to an absence: Students are responsible for finding out what work they may have missed due to an absence.

Assessments

- STAR Standardized testing
- Timed essays
- Socratic Seminar
- Speeches
- Multistage projects

I use STAR Reading assessments throughout the year to monitor student growth, identify learning needs, and guide English Language Arts instruction. I also use Freckle to provide differentiated practice, allowing students to strengthen their reading and language skills at their individual learning levels.

Homework & Study Expectations

Students typically have 60–80 minutes of homework each day. However, students are expected to use their built-in “flex time” to complete homework assignments and other work.

Classroom Rules & Course Expectations

- Stay in your seats
- Practice safety
- Use computers and internet for class purposes only
- Be clean, tidy, and organized
- Be timely
- Be responsible
- Know all your assignments and due dates
- Be prepared

Tips from the Teacher

- Google Classroom: Every student has a login. Ask for their username and password so you can see assignments and feedback.
- PE Uniforms: Leave one set in the classroom cubby — just in case.
- Regular Uniforms: Keep a spare polo in the cubby; recess can be sweaty.
- “Read with a Stutter”: Re-read! If we finished reading a book, story, or passage, we read it again, and again, and again. Once is not enough.

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